

For years, independent game development was a hobby and revenue-generating games featuring alien creatures were created by large teams with loads of money in established game development companies. Before the mid-90s, commercial game distribution was controlled by big publishers and retailers and indie game developers were forced to either build their own publishing houses, or find publishers to distribute their games commercially. If none of that worked, all they could do was distribute it as shareware.

Only when e-commerce and digital distribution came into the picture did it become feasible for indie game developers to make money from their games. Digital distribution platforms such as Apple App Store, Chrome Web Store and Android Market and XBLIG (Xbox Live Indie Games) make it a piece of cake to distribute your game to a focused market.

With new platforms and numerous Open Source game engines and SDKs, it's now possible to make games with small teams and earn good money (if players love it, of course). Programmers can find lots of free art and graphics. Artists can either find freelance programmers to help them with the code or use starter kits or easy game engines such as Game Salad. Chapter 7 of this book discusses various tips and tricks which may help you in developing your own game.

To make a living from indie games, first get yourself a business-minded partner if the business aspect scares or bores you. If indie game development is not your cup of tea, you could master the required skills and try out your luck at game development companies as a programmer, artist or animator.

Before choosing Game Development as your career, you need to identify your interest and then build your skills accordingly. Whether it is concept art, UI design or background art? And what do you want to do – network programming, graphic programming or physics programming? Chapter 5 and 6 of this book will help you better understand the game development process and various roles that you could take up in a game company along with skills you need to develop to be eligible for those roles. Brace yourself – there's a lot to explore!

Next, let's look at what exactly makes a game a game. 